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ADULT CHILDREN OF EMOTIONALLY IMMATURE PARENTS



HOW TO HEAL FROM DISTANT, REJECTING, OR SELF-INVOLVED PARENTS

AGENDA



01. WHAT IS EMOTIONAL IMMATURITY?

02. EMOTIONAL LONELINESS

03. THE FOUR PARENT TYPES

04. HOW CHILDREN COPE

05. BREAKING FREE

WHAT IS EMOTIONAL IMMATURITY?



An emotionally immature parent may meet a child's physical needs but struggles to meet their emotional needs.

Self-involved: the parent's needs come first.

Low empathy: it's hard for them to tune in to the child's feelings.

Rigid thinking: black-and-white, "my way" views.

Emotionally reactive: they overreact, then avoid deeper feelings.

Emotional takeover: their moods set the tone for the whole family.



Emotional Loneliness

A child can be fed, housed and cared for, and still feel unseen.

- They feel alone even when others are around.
- They learn that their feelings are "too much" or don't matter.
- They become the "helper" or "easy kid" to keep the peace.
- As adults, they may feel drained in relationships that should feel close.

Key idea: Emotional loneliness comes from a lack of connection, not a lack of care.

THE FOUR TYPES OF EMOTIONALLY IMMATURE PARENTS

Four patterns to recognize

Emotional: unstable and easily overwhelmed. The family walks on eggshells.

Driven: busy and perfectionistic. They try to "fix" or control the child.

Passive: pleasant but checked out. They avoid conflict and don't protect.

Rejecting: distant or dismissive. They want to be left alone.



Internalizers

Internalizers look inward. They're sensitive, self-reflective and try harder.

They tend to blame themselves, take care of others and hide their needs.

Externalizers

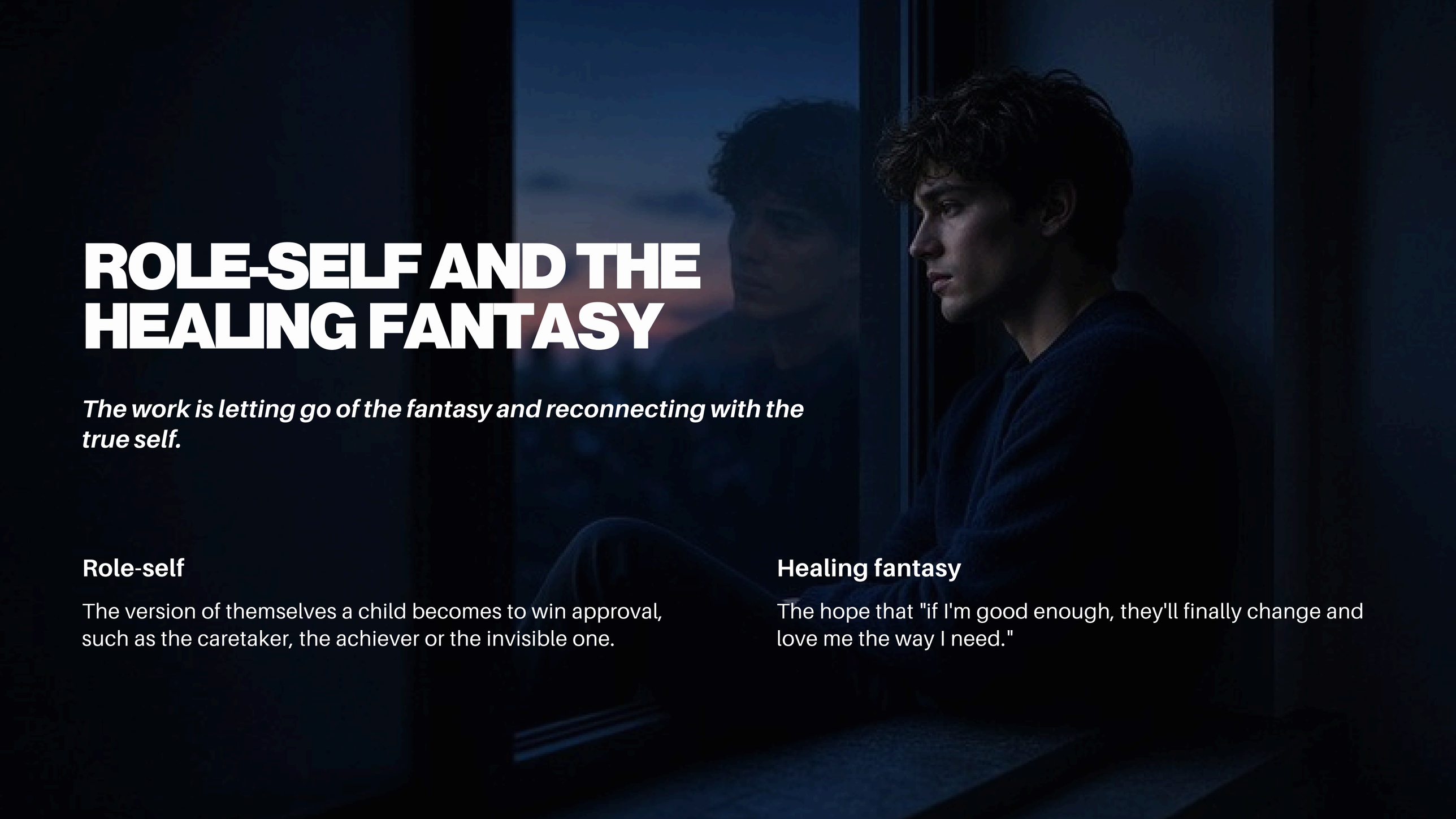
Externalizers act outward. They're impulsive and look for quick relief.

They tend to blame others and expect others to fix problems.

Many people show a mix of both. Neither is "bad"; both are ways to survive.



HOW CHILDREN COPE



ROLE-SELF AND THE HEALING FANTASY

The work is letting go of the fantasy and reconnecting with the true self.

Role-self

The version of themselves a child becomes to win approval, such as the caretaker, the achiever or the invisible one.

Healing fantasy

The hope that "if I'm good enough, they'll finally change and love me the way I need."





Breaking Free: Maturity Awareness

- Observe instead of engage: notice the parent's pattern without getting pulled in.
- Have no expectations: accept who the parent is, not who you wish they were.
- Express yourself, then let go of the outcome.
- Focus on the relationship you can have, not the one you want.
- Trust your own feelings and needs. They matter.



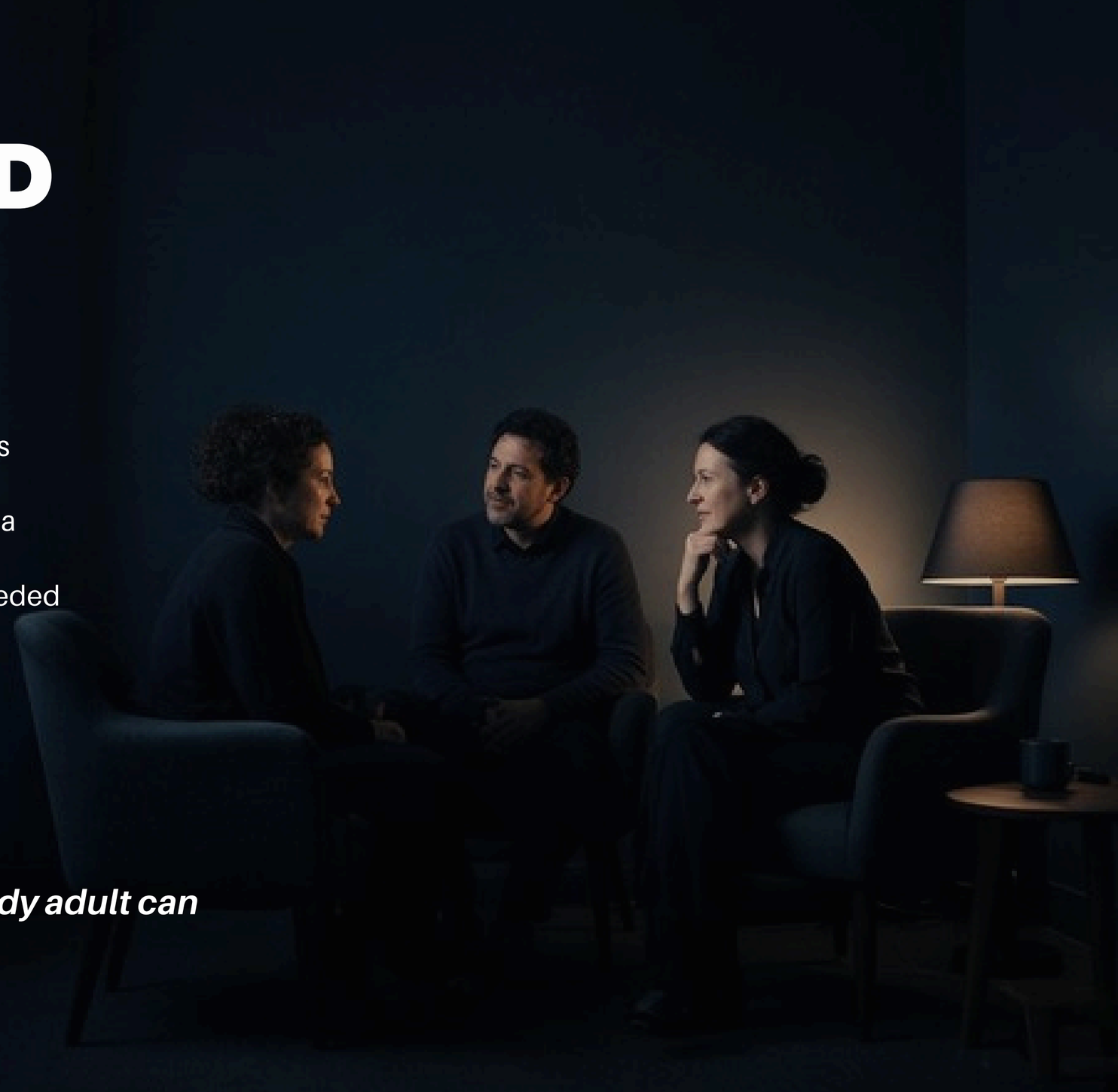
How to Reparent Yourself

Giving yourself the care you needed as a child

- **Notice your inner child.** When a feeling hits hard, ask, “How old do I feel right now?”
- **Name and validate.** Tell yourself what you needed to hear: “Your feelings make sense.”
- **Self-soothe.** Breathe slowly, put a hand on your heart, or wrap up in something warm.
- **Meet your own needs.** Rest, eat, move, and play without needing permission.
- **Set loving limits.** Protect your time and energy, and follow through kindly.
- **Speak with compassion.** Swap the critical voice for the voice of a caring adult.
- **Choose safe people.** Build relationships where you can be your true self.

You can’t change your childhood, but you can become the steady adult you needed.

REFLECTION AND TAKEAWAYS



Reflect

1. Which coping style, internalizer or externalizer, feels most familiar to you?
2. How can you stay calm and not get "taken over" by a parent's emotions?
3. What's one way you can offer yourself what you needed as a child this week?

Takeaway

Emotional maturity is learned, and one steady adult can make a difference.

QUESTIONS?

THANK YOU

GIBSON, L. C. (2015). ADULT CHILDREN OF EMOTIONALLY IMMATURE PARENTS. NEW HARBINGER PUBLICATIONS.